tensions and political controversy,' Honecker noted. 'The worldwide economic crisis was already looming on the horizon.' In fact, it didn't take long for the contagion to reach Weimar Germany, sending the country into the abyss. A well-known saying at the time stated: 'New York sneezed, London caught cold, and Germany nearly died of influenza.' In the winter of 1928-29, unemployment had stood at 2.5 million, by the following winter the figure was pushed up to 3 million, as the economy contracted, and thousands of small firms folded. There was an almost constant state of anxiety as other predictable traumas, including tuberculosis and pneumonia, spread among the population in epidemic numbers. But there was more going on at this time. Before long, the situation handed impetus to an upstart political party from Munich – the National Socialists, or Nazis, led by Adolf Hitler, a man of monumental vitriol who used victimhood to spout a mishmash of banal ideas. Although vague on actual policies, Hitler gave the people enemies such as Jews and communists, blaming them for the financial crisis and for 'stabbing Germany in the back' during the war.

Amid this tumult and stress, the KJVD Central Committee delegated Honecker to visit Moscow to study Marxism-Leninism for a year. 'My parents agreed to my taking this course,' he remembered. 'And so, just before my 18th birthday, I went filled with expectations.' According to his own account, he packed his few belongings in August 1930 and set-off filled with boyhood optimism. There was a brief stop in Berlin for an interview with the Central Committee at the Karl Liebknecht House, near Alexanderplatz – the gritty district known for street battles and brawls between communists and increasingly confident Nazis, both fighting for influence in the city. While he didn't experience any violence, he did glimpse the dying days of Weimar Berlin, thick with risqué cabarets, prostitutes and black marketeers. Strange as it sounds, his most exciting moment was seeing a stage performance at the Volksbuhne – the people's stage – a 3,600-seat theatre opposite the KPD headquarters. A short course at the 'Reichsparteischule der KPD' – the Communist Party school in Fichtenau followed, where teachers marked him diligent and competitive.